

# fridayReview

THE HINDU

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Narendra Kusnur

In 2017, Bharatanatyam exponent and dance critic Indumati Raman published her first book *Bhagavata Mela: My Tryst With Tradition*. It focused on Bhagavata Mela, the temple dance-theatre tradition practised and performed by male Brahmins from Thanjavur. Her study of the subject also led her to explore the world of Marathi Yaksaganams in her book *Dance-Theatre By Thanjavur Maratha Rajas* (Motilal Banarsidass Publishing House).  
“Thanjavur is a religious, linguistic and cultural centre since the time of the Cholas. The Maratha dynasty took over Thanjavur and reigned for two centuries after the Nayaks. This era, 1676-1855, is widely regarded as one of the most artistically and intellectually vibrant periods in South Indian history,” says Indumati, adding that despite their immense contribution to literature, music and dance, the history of the Thanjavur Marathas remains largely neglected in modern discourse. “The book aims to bring their sophisticated multi-lingual heritage back into the spotlight,” she adds.  
According to Indumati, the Maratha kings of Thanjavur were more than just rulers. They were scholars and artistes fluent in Marathi, Telugu, Sanskrit and Tamil. In the book, she introduces readers to Marathi Yaksaganams, a unique genre of south Indian dance-theatre where stories unfold through poetic verses, music and dialogue.  
The Mumbai-based author clarifies that Yaksaganams are not to be confused with the Yakshagana of Karnataka. She elaborates, “What I am talking about is the drama format that originated in the 15th century during the Vijayanagar reign and later developed by the Maratha rulers.”

Another misconception is that Thanjavur Marathas came from Maharashtra. Indumati points out, “They came from Thanjavur. Their education was in Tamil, Telugu, Sanskrit and Hindi. They were musicians, poets and scholars of Natya Sastra and Alankara Sastra. Yes, their mother-tongue



## Thanjavur's cultural crown

In tracing the evolution of the Bhagavata Mela tradition under Maratha patronage, Indumati Raman's book maps its ritual roots, aesthetic shifts and hereditary performers

was Marathi.”

Indumati has also recently released the book *Sumathi Tyagaraja*, published by Qurate as a historical fiction homage to saint-composer Tyagaraja. An alumna of Kalakshetra, she showed an interest in Bhagavata Mela from her childhood. “As a schoolgirl, I had a scrap book.

Obsessed with dance, I collected photos and newspaper articles on Bhagavata Mela, and read interviews of dancers. When I joined Kalakshetra in 1966, the Bhagavata Mela guru Balu Bhagavata was on the campus. My guru Rukmini Devi was fascinated with the Bhagavata Mela drama format and adapted elements of it to the famous Kalakshetra dance-dramas.”

Indumati began deeply researching the subject after she visited Melattur in Thanjavur in 1993. Before that, as an arts writer, she had attended the staging of the Bhagavata Mela production *Rukmini Kalyanam* at the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) in Mumbai. She met the artistes backstage and heard their problems

and challenges. A defining moment took place a few months later when she was invited to attend the Narasimha Jayanti celebrations in Melattur. She was floored by the experience, particularly the performance of *Prahlada Charitam*. She says, “I was also invited to officiate as chairperson. As a timid 40-something, the task appeared formidable. How can I manage a group of 20 traditional and conservative pandits and actors? Trained in the Kalakshetra style, I decided not to comment or change their

**A cradle of arts** (From left) Bhagavata Mela artistes performing *Rukmini Kalyanam* in 2023; *Prahalada Charitam* at Melattur in 2011; Indumati Raman; and the Thanjavur Palace. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



**The Maratha dynasty took over Thanjavur and reigned for two centuries after the Nayaks. This era is regarded as one of the most artistically vibrant periods in South Indian history**

INDUMATI RAMAN

style of dance. They had learned the art from the devadasis of that time. I could appreciate that. But what worried me was that I was breaking into an ancient male bastion of traditional temple dance-theatre.”

Indumati's new journey had, of course, begun. She says, “My vision for revival of the art was to make them perform outside, bring them into the limelight and write extensively about the tradition. A three-day festival in January 1994 in Mumbai drew houseful shows. Besides five more festivals in Mumbai, Chennai and Tiruvaiyaru, we had many other events over the next 10 years.”

The performances included the Marathi dance-drama *Sakuntala*. She recalls, “Being based in Mumbai, my interest and curiosity led me into Marathi Yaksaganams. Most Bharatanatyam dancers and Carnatic musicians are familiar with Marathi abhangs and bhajans, especially those made famous by Guru Haridoss Giri. Parvati Kumar, guru of Bharatanatyam exponent and Sangeet Natak Akademi chairperson Sandhya Purecha, was the first to compose and choreograph the compositions of Maratha rulers such as Serfoji Raje and Sahaji Raje. However, Marathi Yaksaganams still didn't gain much popularity.”

For 2018-19, Indumati was awarded the National Tagore Fellowship. Her subject was ‘Dance-Theatre of the Thanjavur Rajas’. The research helped her compile the book, which is divided into three parts. The first provides a historical background of Yaksaganams with chapters on the Bhakti movement, Bharatamuni's Natya Sastra, the Melattur Bhagavata Mela tradition, the Maratha dynasty in Thanjavur and the music and dance traditions of Maharashtra.

This is followed by sections examining the design and rhetoric of two rare multi-lingual Yaksaganams — *Sakuntalanatak Yaksaganam* by Bavaasheh Ekoji II and *Mritunjaya Chiranjiva Yaksaganam* by Sahaji Raje Bhosle II. The book includes the original Devanagari script, alongside English transliterations and translations, and detailed annotations explaining cultural nuances and sociological contexts. It is a comprehensive resource for historians, practitioners of Indian classical dance and lovers of Bhagavata Mela.

### Celebrating the Bhagavata legacy

The Bhagavata Mela Natya Nataka Sangam, Melattur, presents its 86th Mahotsav on the occasion of Sri Narasimha Jayanti Vasantotsav. The event will be held from April 30 to May 8 at Sri Varadaraja Perumal Sannidhi.

The event begins on April 30 (7.30 a.m.) with ‘Poorvangam’ at Sri Rudralayam Sree Siddhi Buddhi Dakshinamoorthy Vinayakar Temple and Sri Varadaraja Perumal temple.

On May 1, 9 p.m.: inauguration of the mahotsavam, followed by the staging of the iconic ‘Prahlada Charitam’ at 9.30 p.m. May 2, 8 p.m.: ‘Nrityanjali’ — a dance recital by Natya Sankalpa School of Bharatanatyam; at 9 p.m. ‘Agre Pashyami’ — The Divine in Front of Me, Narasimha Avataram’ — will be presented by Anitha Guha's Bharatanjali. Concept and narration are by Dushyanth Sridhar and choreography is by Anitha.

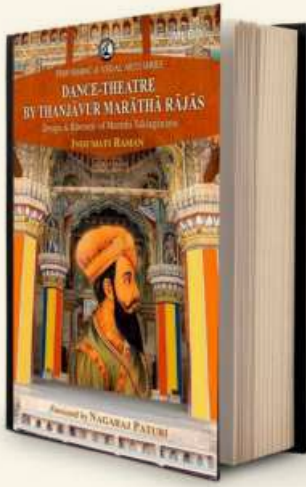
May 3, 9.30 p.m.: Bhagavata Mela dance drama ‘Harishchandra’ Part 1 followed by Part 2 on May 4, 9.30 p.m.

May 5, 8 p.m.: A lecture by R. Vaithianathan of Sarasa Endowment, Mumbai, on ‘Bhagavata Mela Tradition through the lens of the Bhagavad Gita’; 8.15 p.m.: ‘Aranum Angayarkanniyam’ — a dance drama by member artistes of ABHA; 9.15 p.m.: ‘Vipranarayana Charitramu’ a Kuchipudi Yakshaganam by Sri Sai Manjeera Kuchipudi Art Academy. Written by Thanjavur Nayaka king Vijayaraghava Nayakudu in the 17th century, it is choreographed by Kaza Venkata Subramanyam.

May 6, 8 p.m.: Mohiniyattam by Neena Prasad; 9.30 p.m.: Bhagavata Mela Natakam's ‘Sree Krishna Jananam - Kamsa Vadham’.

May 7, 8 p.m.: Tamil play ‘Thirumurugatrupadi’ by Nataka Kavalar Chemal R.S. Manohar's NXGs. It is written by K.P. Arivanandham, directed by S. Sruthi and S. Shivprasad. This will be followed by ‘Valli Thirumanam’.

May 8, 6 p.m.: Anjaneya utsavam and procession.



### Upholding a tradition

Sri Lakshmi Narasimha Bhagavatha Mela Bhaktha Samajam, Saliyamangalam, Thanjavur district, will host the 381st Sri Narasimha Jayanti from April 28 to May 2. Procession of the presiding deity, music concerts and staging of Bhagavata Mela dance dramas form part of the five-day festival. Preliminary rituals, on April 28 and 29, include the rendition of Ashtapadi and divyanamam, while Radha kalyanam will be performed by

Haridwaramangalam Ramgopal Bhagavata.

The line-up on April 30 includes the installation ceremony of Lakshmi Narasimha, vasantotsavam of Sri Bhoomineela samedha Srinivasa Perumal (6 p.m.), procession of the presiding deity at Saliyamangalam, also known as Achyutapuram, on Garuda vahanam (7 p.m.) followed by the staging of *Prahlada Charitram* (10 p.m.) which culminate in Sri

Narasimha Avataram on May 1 at 4 a.m. The festival concludes with Anjaneya utsavam on May 2, 7 p.m. The Narasimha Jayanti utsavam at Saliyamangalam has been taking place since 1645.

In the 16th century, when the Nayaks were ruling Thanjavur, nearly 400 Bhagavata families migrated from Vijayanagara to Thanjavur to propagate their culture and performing arts, which gave rise to the Bhagavata Mela. This age-old art form flourished in and around Thanjavur and was originally performed in six villages — Saliyamangalam, Melattur,

Thepperumanallur, Oothukadu, Soolamangalam and Nallur. Today, the tradition survives only in Melattur and Saliyamangalam.

Until the 1930s, Bhagavata Mela featured five annual productions — *Prahlada Charitram*, *Rukmini Kalyanam*, *Vipranarayana Charitram*, *Rukmangatha Charitram* and *Sita Kalyanam* — of which only *Prahlada Charitram* and *Rukmini Kalyanam* continue to be staged at Saliyamangalam. These dramas are performed in Telugu, drawing on the rich literary tradition of *Pothana Bhagavatam*.





String story (Left) Debjit Mahalanobis and (below) his guru Ustad Bahauddin Dagar. PHOTOS SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

stage of the Gajveena’s making. “I stopped playing other instruments, and stayed put in West Bengal, until the Gajveena took shape,” he recalls. While only a few knew about Debjit’s tryst with the Gajveena, he was still practicing how to play the instrument when he applied for the Guthman competition. “I was lucky enough to be selected as one of the 10 finalists, even though travelling to the programme was a different adventure altogether,” he says.

When the attacks began in West Asia on February 28, the Gajveena – packed in a humongous protective crate that weighed nearly 500 kg – was in Delhi. “Since the courier company found the instrument too large to transport, it was flown to Hong Kong, and then somewhere in between, it was transported across the Pacific Ocean as an unaccompanied cargo,” laughs Debjit. “Meanwhile, I had to reschedule my flights, and flew through Mumbai, London, New York City and then Atlanta. The Gajveena reached the East Coast, and then it took us a few more days to get it to my uncle’s house on the West Coast,” recalls Debjit.

The unprecedented delays in getting the right transport meant that Debjit got only five minutes to prepare for his stage showcase at Georgia Tech.

Debjit was encouraged by the response to the Gajveena from his fellow contestants . “A couple of them were double bass players, and when they tried this instrument, they loved it because they could play it in an upright position as most Indian instruments are meant to be played with the artiste seated on the floor.”

To him the Gajveena is a ‘sampoorna’ (complete) instrument. “Even if one does not know how to bend strings and achieve gamaka (a rapid, oscillating movement on a note or between notes), the weight of the frequency is such that even in straight notes, it has got a long sustain. Each of the notes can stand for more than 12-14 seconds,” elaborates Debjit.

According to him, fusion is not a new term in the world of music. “The sitar follows the grammar of the Persian setar and Indian veena. The sarod comes from the Afghani rabab. So, the classical instruments that we now consider Indian are actually fusion instruments. Music is like a river, it simply follows its own path,” he says.

Nahla Nainar

India’s rich music traditions continue to shape new instruments and ideas. In mid-March, the Gajveena, a statuesque instrument that blends the looks and sound of the double bass and rudra veena, made a striking debut at the Guthman Musical Instrument Competition, organised at the Georgia Tech campus in Atlanta.

Though it did not win a prize, its inventor and noted Indian double bassist and composer Debjit Mahalanobis is thrilled to have showcased it on the world stage. “I was one of the 10 finalists at the competition and the Gajveena was the only acoustic instrument in the running. It could be crafted because of my guru Ustad Bahauddin Dagar, who also coined its name,” shares Debjit over a call from Georgia.

“The ‘gaj’ in Gajveena could mean an elephant or also an older connotation of ‘board’. In the Western world too, the sound of the double bass has been compared to that of elephants,” he adds. The lower portion of the Gajveena resembles that of a double bass. Standing at a towering six ft 11 inches, it is fitted with a 42-inch fretted fingerboard and dual resonators. It offers microtonal control, deep-drone textures and real-time string bending, with its sound travelling

# Global resonance

How double bass artiste Debjit Mahalanobis’ Gajveena made it to the Guthman Musical Instrument Competition in Atlanta



from the lower body through a hollow neck conduit to an upper tumba resonator near the ear. “This is the first instrument that can be plucked just like the veena and bowed like a double bass. The board and double bass are obviously Western, but the tonal and timbral quality is just like the Indian veena,” says Debjit.

It has been a six-year journey for Debjit, who first envisioned the instrument in 2018, while learning to play the rudra veena from Ustad Bahauddin Dagar. The young musician hails from a distinguished lineage – scientist and statistician P.C. Mahalanobis on the paternal side, and musician Pt. Ramshankar Bhattacharya

(founder of the Bishnupur Dhrupad Dhamar gharana), from his maternal side. Debjit has worked with two instrument makers in Kolkata – Ranjit Roy and Dipen Das – for close to two years to see the Gajveena take shape. “Luthiers are hard to find in India. I was fortunate to have worked with Ranjit Roy (of Roy Music Centre), who was my original double bass maker, whom I have known for more than 15 years. Dipen Das (of D.K. Das and Sons), who comes from a case-making background is a first generation veena maker and was also taught by Ustad Bahauddin Dagar. Much later I learnt that Ustad had asked Dipen to create what I wanted without asking me too many questions,” says Debjit. Over five months, short of cutting the wood (maple, spruce and ebony), Debjit was closely involved in every

# Notes from the KVN school

Hemmige Prashanth’s choice of ragas and kritis was a fitting tribute to his guru

N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Hemmige S. Prashanth’s performance was rooted in the aesthetic of his guru, the legendary K.V. Narayanaswamy. Accompanied by V.S.P. Gayatri Sivani on the violin, V.R. Srinivasan on the mridangam and Trichy Murali on the ghatam, the evening featured a remarkable line-up of songs. Beginning with the Nattai varnam ‘Sarasijanaabha’ by Palakkad Parameshwara Bhagavathar, Prashanth went in for the lesser-heard Kedaram composition ‘Tyagaraja gurum ashraye’, composed by M.D. Ramanathan on Tyagaraja in

Tisra Adi tala. Created using the Dikshitar mould replete with a madhyama kala sahityam, this kriti features both the raga mudra and the composer’s mudra. An alapana in Anandabhairavi followed, which had many characteristic phrases condensed well within its short duration. ‘O jagadamba’, a song immortalised by KVN, was taken up by Prashanth with an engaging niraval . In the rendition of Papanasam Sivan’s ‘Manam irangadha’ in Mayamalavagowla (Rupaka tala), the alapana stood out for being thorough. Every phrase captured the foundational gravity of the raga, offering a



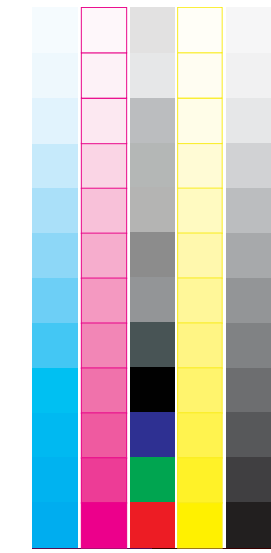
clear and focused introduction that avoided unnecessary clutter. The transition into the kriti led to a sophisticated niraval at the phrase ‘Paadi panindhu bhaktar.’ The rendition of Tyagaraja’s ‘Evvari mata’ in Kamboji, as the main composition, tests a singer’s breath control and rhythmic precision because of its architectural grandeur. The structure of the composition allows for a steady build-up of

energy, which is essential for a main piece. Prashanth’s alapana eschewed flashiness, and the niraval and swaras were marked by clarity and rhythmic grace. The highlight was the daivata kuraippu in the final swara, which served as an effective melodic anchor. Much like KVN’s style, the kalpanaswaras built anticipation through precise ideas, maintaining a soulful raga bhava even as the tempo

escalated. Gayatri Sivani displayed musical maturity, with her alapanas standing out. Her synchronisation with the vocalist during the manodharma sections made for a lucid listening experience. Srinivasan and Murali provided a robust percussive foundation that complemented the vocalist’s style. KVN was undoubtedly a master of viruthams, which

stood out for their sahitya shuddham, ensuring the lyrics remained intelligible through complex melodic phrases. Prashanth employed the Ariyakkudi style of transition, shifting between ragas with technical seamlessness. A key feature was his ability to establish a raga’s swaroopa (identity) using only a few foundational notes, allowing for a comprehensive presentation despite the short

duration of each segment. Prashanth presented ‘Ayi murali’ and ‘Amsaalambitha vaama kundala bharam’ from Sri Krishna Karnamrutham in the same vein before ending with a Tiruppavai.



# A space to shine

Bhairavi Venkatesan performed as part of Sridevi Nrithyalaya’s initiative to showcase talented students

V.V. Ramani

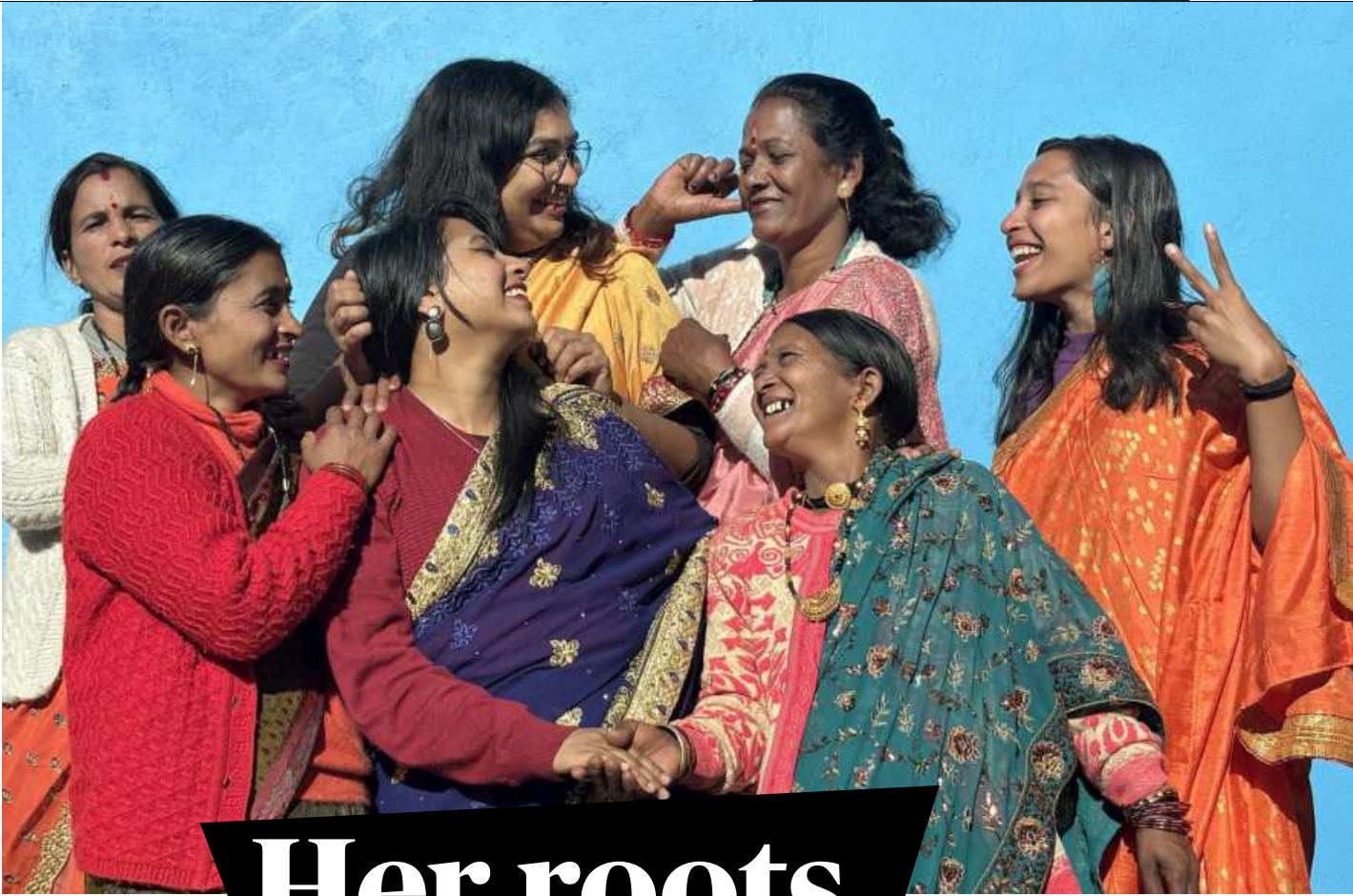
A formidable team of veteran musicians on the dais could prove challenging for an up-and-coming dancer, but Bhairavi Venkatesan used it to her advantage in her performance at SDN’s Kriya festival at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. Ideated by Sheela Unnikrishnan, this annual programme provides an opportunity to talented dancers from her school, Sridevi Nrithyalaya, to choose a theme and put together a margam based on it. The entire logistics of the presentation is taken care of by Sheela. Bhairavi chose compositions by the Thanjavur Quartet. Preceded by a swaravali, the classic ‘Amba neelayadakshi’ in raga Nilambari was the opening piece. Musically rich, this composition describes the attributes of goddess Jagadamba. And Bhairavi’s visualisation was marked by restrained elegance. A jatiswaram in raga

Purvikalyani (Sankeerna nadai Adi tala) was followed by the popular Khamas varnam ‘Swamiyai azhathodi’, which showcased Bhairavi’s training and creative approach. The emotions of love, anguish and anticipation were conveyed through varied sancharis marked by subtle shifts in expressions. The rhythmic flourishes of Guru Bharadwaj’s mridangam and Srikanth Gopalakrishnan’s soulful rendition set the mood for the dancer to establish the sthayi bhava of the nayika with clarity. Violinist Nandini Sai Girdhar and flautist Sujit Naik enriched the musical appeal. Nattuvangam was handled with competence by Mridula Shivkumar. ‘Mutta vadhura’ a javali in raga Saveri was a study in contrast, where the nayika is angry with her hero’s wayward behaviour. The final thillana in raag Behag with korvais set by Guru Bharadwaj was marked by fluid movements. However, the inherent vibrancy in the piece was missing.



At her creative best Bhairavi Venkatesan. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT





**Of soul and strength**  
(Clockwise from right) Members of Folksoul; and founders Charu Hariharan and Krantinaari.  
PHOTOS COURTESY: BIC AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

**Shilpa Anandraj**  
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Spotlights come on at the Bangalore International Centre in Bengaluru. Seven artistes, from The Nyoli Ensemble are all set to present Folksoul's project 'Sound of Women'. Folk artistes Hemanti Devi, Khasti Devi, Pushpa Devi-Taiji and Chandrashekhar Tamta take the stage along with Shalini Mohan (bass), Charu Hariharan (percussions and vocals) and Krantinaari aka Ashwini Hiremath (rapper and the project curator).

The folk voices carried a raw, earthy timbre – untrained yet powerful and echoed the daily rigours of their lives. In contrast, hip-hop surged with modern beats and sharp rap verses. Together, the performers formed a chorus of identities. The evening unfolded like a seamless conversation among the artistes and genres.

What resonated more with the audience was the way each song was interwoven with tales of struggle, messages on the environment and stories of courage. "That these women never gave up on their music, only proves its

# Her roots, her beats

'Sound of Women', a collective voicing stories of identity and resilience through diverse musical styles



healing power," said Charu. The short and intense performance also included a Konnakol by Charu, where she got the audience to repeat the rhythmic syllables. From a simple 'takadimi, takita' it progressed to more complex patterns; at times turning into tongue-twisters for the audience, making the evening interactive too.

During a conversation after the performance, Charu and Kranti spoke about how the ensemble came together and the larger dream of giving a platform to women's voices. Charu, who directed the ensemble, hails from Kerala and started learning classical music from

her grandfather, Bhagavatheeswara Iyer, and later from her singer-mother B. Arundhathi. She also studied mridangam under Mannarkoil J. Balaji, from the age of 10. Her journey into folk and tribal collaborations, she said, started with the Archival Research Project in Kerala (ARPO). "My brother Srikant Hariharan and I recorded tribal voices in Wayanad and Attapadi." These encounters led to performances at The Mahindra Percussion Festival, where curators "encouraged" her to bring folk and tribal traditions together. This resulted in a fellowship project, supported by Tata Trusts.

Charu credits Kranti for the Nyoli



Ensemble. "After exploring the tribal arts of Uttarakhand, Kranti reached out to me asking if I would be interested to come on board. I agreed and we founded 'Folksoul', with an aim to take such initiatives forward," shared Charu.

For the 'Sound of Women' project, Kranti travelled across 72 regions. "Conversations with peers revealed how disconnected many of us are from our roots. Languages were forgotten, cultural memory eroded. This realisation stayed with me. Folk music, I understood, is not just a performance – it is one of the most powerful forms of documentation we have. It carries stories of culture, climate, caste and lived realities. It is an archive of sound and memory."

According to Kranti, "women sing through every phase of life – lullabies, rituals, celebrations or grief. Though a rapper, I also identify strongly with folk because both are rooted in observation, ask difficult questions and imagine solutions. Rap also gave me access to the world. I learnt English through itrap music, which opened doors to cultures and ideas. It showed me how music can be more than expression – it can be a tool for change."

Charu and Kranti took off to Jeolikote in Uttarakhand, where they stayed for 10 days interacting and working with the folk and tribal artistes. "Some women faced

restrictions – one talented rapper was not allowed to travel with us by her spouse, though this is gradually changing. Grants from Abhivakthi, G5A, Serendipity and Global fund for women helped us launch 'Sound of Women' in Uttarakhand. We were also supported by Manzil Mystics, who provided us a bus equipped with a mobile recording studio. This became a space where we met artistes who were unfamiliar with microphones, headphones or metronomes and together we recorded 35 songs," said Charu, who created rhythm loops to guide the folk artistes, introducing concepts of tempo and key.

Nyoli Ensemble takes its name from Nyoli songs, which are spontaneous, oral compositions. "Like Marathi Ovi (Ovya) couplets, Nyolis are cathartic, often sung by women as they work, expressing pain, resilience and defiance. One of the artistes, Pushpadevi, took up the huduka percussion after her husband abandoned her, defying tradition that only men played it. Another singer, Hemanti, is the daughter of Kabutari Devi, a pioneering Kumaoni folk singer and the first woman from Uttarakhand to feature on All India Radio (AIR) in the 1970s. Hemanti carries forward her mother's legacy. Kashi, another singer, balances agriculture, childcare and music. Each woman's story is marked by trials, yet art remains their anchor," said Charu.

## The Kashalkar method

Sumana Ramanan's book is a portrait of an artiste shaped as much by inward enquiry and lineage as by performance

**Deepa Ganesh**

There are several kinds of musicians. Some are performers, who engage with the audience and enjoy the applause and recognition. They bring their full energy into the moment; performance and reception become the primary location of their art. Then there are those who are quiet custodians of the form; they remain largely unfazed by worldly validation. They may not always be widely known, but their influence runs deep, shaping generations of artistes.

These are, of course, not rigid categories. At times, one sees traces of one in the other.

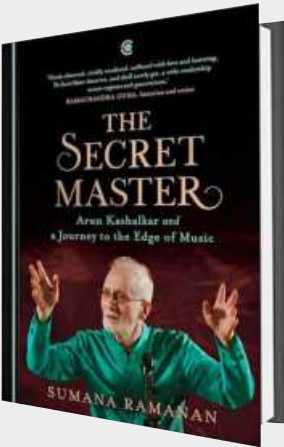
There was a time when musicians were valued as repositories of knowledge and not just as stage personalities. They embodied the art they inherited, serving as carriers of cultural memory. Without such as artistes, traditions risk dilution, or worse, become merely performative. *The Secret Master: Arun Kashalkar and a Journey to the Edge of Music* by journalist-turned-author Sumana Ramanan (Context Books), shows how Arun Kashalkar fits the description of a keeper of a tradition.

While the narrative recognises his distinct place among connoisseurs, within pedagogical lineages, and as a custodian of multiple musical traditions, there are moments where it appears to register a quiet unease with the implications of such a position. For instance, the chapter that mentions Durga Jasraj introduces a subtle counterpoint, hinting at an alternative trajectory – one that might have brought him greater visibility and public recognition.

Yet, the book stops short of

recasting Arun through that lens. Instead, it locates him firmly within a broader lineage of musicians whose greatness has often unfolded away from the public gaze – artistes for whom depth, continuity and inheritance take precedence over acclaim. It is from this very idea that the book draws its title, *The Secret Master: Arun Kashalkar and a Journey to the Edge of Music*, echoing an earlier invocation by First Edition Arts, which, about a decade ago, featured Arun Kashalkar under the evocative rubric 'Secret Masters.'

The book is not merely a biography; but also extends into wide-ranging discussions on cultural concerns, both general and specific to music. It reflects on arts funding, the role of profit-driven institutions, and the influence of the media on artistic practice. Alongside these are explorations of the raga form and its relationship to human language, as well as detailed engagements with music theory – from foundational concepts such



as pitch to the intricate clustering and deployment of swaras within a raga.

Structurally, it weaves together multiple strands. Episodes from Arun Kashalkar's life alongside musical histories rooted in the lineage he embodies are interspersed with extended thematic discussions and autobiographical reflections, creating a layered and dialogic narrative. In doing so, the book moves beyond the confines of conventional biography, but

adopts a structure that can at times feel unwieldy. The frequent shifts between narrative strands make it demanding for the reader, who must oscillate between the varied registers of the text, and this shuffling back and forth occurs rather too often.

At other points, the extended discussions on the history of Hindustani classical music, the gharana system, and the technical components of music are overly elaborate. Additionally, the book appears to address a mixed audience – the initiated and the general reader – which, at times, weighs on the overall reading experience.

That said, this expansiveness also signals the ambition of the work: an attempt to situate the life of Arun Kashalkar within a larger intellectual, historical and musical landscape. If it occasionally strains the reading experience, it is perhaps in service of a fuller, more layered engagement with the art form.

What emerges with particular force is the making of the modern musician – one who, while negotiating the demands of life alongside a deep commitment to his art, sustains a strong sense of integrity and value. The passages – detailing his early learning from his father N.D. Kashalkar, his bond with his gurus, and the many struggles and choices that shape a thinking artiste – are especially compelling. Equally engaging are the glimpses into how he builds a life alongside his spouse, and how disciples gradually enter and transform that world.

*The Secret Master: Arun Kashalkar and a Journey to the Edge of Music* through its layered narrative, it brings into focus Arun Kashalkar as an artiste shaped as much by inward enquiry and lineage as by performance.



### CALENDAR

#### Song and string



**April 26, 4 p.m.:** Veena duet by Shubhaangi and Hiranmayee, students of Veenavaadhini. 4.35 p.m.: Kolkata S. Aishwarya (vocal); 6.30 p.m.: Akkarai Subhalakshmi and Akkarai Sornalatha (violin).

#### Sadasiva Brahmendral aradhana

Sadguru Sri Sadhasiva Brahmendral Aradhana Committee has organised a two-day event (April 25 and 26) to mark the 46th aradhana of Sadasiva Brahmendral, at Manamadurai. Aradhana, unchavritti, ghosti ganam, music concerts and discourses will take place at M.S.P.A. Unnamalai Ammal Marriage Hall.

On the occasion, violin vidwan A.G. Venkatasubramanian and mridangam vidwan A.S. Ranganathan will be honoured.

Day one begins with unchavritti at 7 a.m. followed by vocal and instrumental concerts featuring established and up-and-coming musicians (from 8.30 a.m. to 7 p.m.); Srimushnam Rajarao's Layavinyasam (8 p.m.) and Senkottai Harihara Subramanian's divya namasankirtanam (9 p.m.). Programmes on day two will begin with unchavritti at 7 a.m. and will be followed by ghosti ganam, special pujas and Anjaneyar utsavam at Sri Somanathar temple.



#### Lecture

Kedaram has organised a special lecture by violinist vidwan R.K. Shriram Kumar on the sangeetam and sahityam of Syama Sastri kritis on April 27, 6.15 p.m. at Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Mylapore. The event is being held in connection with the Syama Sastri day celebrations. He will be supported by vocalist Amritha Murali, violinist Madan Mohan and mridangist Arun Prakash.

#### Annamacharya day

The Music Academy's Annamacharya day celebrations will feature T.P. Chakrapani's vocal concert today at 6 p.m. K.V. Krishna on the violin and Kumbakonam K. Swaminathan on the mridangam will accompany. The programme, has been organised under the endowment, instituted by P. Obul Reddy and P. Gnanamba. Venue: Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

#### Anniversary special

ISKCON Chennai will celebrate its 14th anniversary on April 26 from 6 p.m. at Akkarai, ECR. To mark the occasion, special *pushpa abhisekam* will be performed to the presiding deities, Radha Krishna and Nitai Gauranga.





Shailaja Tripathi

Jivya Soma Mashe was an incredible artist who brought Warli painting out of the walls of tribal homes and into the realm of contemporary art. Rooted in the Warli community of Maharashtra, this art form was traditionally practised by women during rituals, painted with rice paste on mud walls. Mashe shifted this practice to paper and canvas without losing its connection to everyday life, Nature and community.

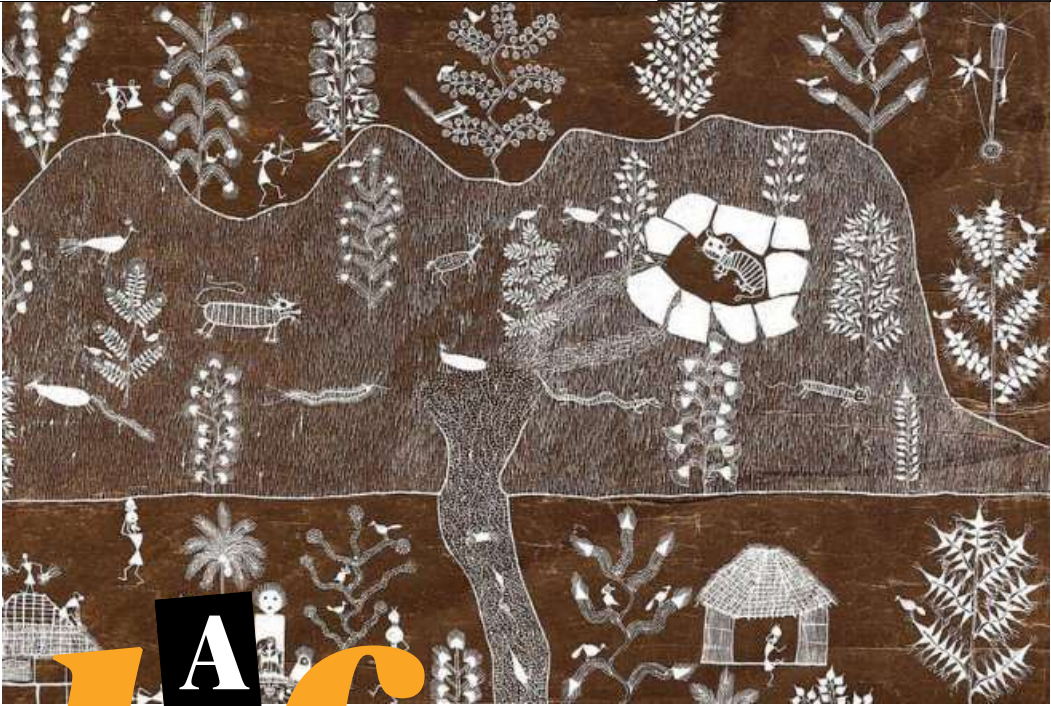
His works are marked by simplicity and repetition – human figures, animals, farming scenes and the well-known circular tarpa dance. This simplicity is laced with a deep sensitivity to movement, time and balance. His practice wasn't isolated from his life, it was a natural extension of it. Mashe received the National Award for Tribal Art in 1976 and the Padma Shri in 2011. He passed away in 2018.

French art critic and curator Hervé Perdriolle first met Mashe in the late 1990s, and what began as a search gradually turned into a long, enduring friendship. Over the years, Perdriolle spent time with Mashe in his village, observing not just his art but his way of living. Despite language differences, their connection grew through shared time, gestures and a quiet understanding.

This led to a book on Jivya Soma Mashe. Created over decades, the book brings together rare images and personal memories.

During an interview, Perdriolle talks about documenting with care Mashe's life and art.

**Question:** What do you remember about your first meeting with Jivya Soma Mashe?  
**Answer:** I first met him in 1997. At that time, there was no



# A life in lines

French art critic and curator Hervé Perdriolle's book takes readers into the world of Warli master Jivya Soma Mashe

Internet, and telecommunications were unreliable. I was living in Pondicherry (from 1996 to 1999), more than 1,300 km away from Warli. During my first visit to Warli, Mashe was not there. I met his family, discovered his home and learned about his environment. I met him for the first time on my second trip, for barely an hour, when I went to invite him for a workshop in Delhi. He was getting ready to go to the river to wash his clothes, as men of his tribe do. The third time was the best. My persistence paid off. He spoke to me in Varli, I, in French. It was the beginning of a beautiful and true friendship. We often met on his land, in France or in Germany. Alongside his



painting, he continued to work in the fields. This dual activity nourished his imagination and preserved his sensitivity.

**Q:** What was it about Mashe's work that inspired you to work

with him?  
**A:** Upon arriving in India, I read books on Indian tribal art, in general, and on Warli art, in particular, at the library of the French School of Asian Studies in Pondicherry. In Yashodhara



**Folk Imprints**  
(clockwise from far left) Human figures, animals, farming scenes, and the circular tarpa dance in Mashe's works; his 1997 piece Rice Season in acrylic and cow dung on canvas; and with the author. PHOTOS: HERVE PERDRIOLLE AND T. VENKANNA

Dalmia's book *The Painted World of the Warli*, I photocopied the small map of the Warli lands, and then retraced the steps of the first Indian emissaries sent by Pupul Jayakar to the subcontinent's most representative tribes, especially those of Bhaskar Kulkarni. Thanks to them, I met Mashe and was impressed by his simplicity.

**Q:** When you watched him paint, what did you notice about his creative process?

**A:** To watch Jivya Soma Mashe paint was like seeing a millennia-old culture come alive. His constant attention to detail was awe-inspiring. The recurring theme of the fishing net showcased his contemplative approach. Almost always large in scale, they depicted a multitude of delicate circles forming the net's mesh, repeated ad infinitum. Each painted circle was both similar and different, like mantras modulated endlessly.

**Q:** What made you come up with this book?

**A:** This book is a tribute, of course, but also a testament to an encounter and to a friendship. Every year for

nearly 20 years, I was accumulating a wealth of archival material. I would have loved to publish this book while Mashe was alive. The book was practically completed more than 10 years ago. It was only recently that I found the funding to release it. The Cartier Foundation and a few friends, all collectors of iconic works of Jivya Soma Mashe, contributed. It has been published by 5 Continents Editions and Roli Books.

**Q:** What do you hope readers would understand about Mashe through this book?

**A:** I hope this book allows readers to fully appreciate the quality of Mashe's works revealed particularly in the details of his paintings, which reflect his profound sensitivity. That is why I prioritised the reproduction of numerous details in the book's design. The book also seeks to broaden our understanding of contemporary art.

**Q:** Does it contain rare and unpublished works, stories or images?

**A:** As this is the first book entirely dedicated to Mashe's work, all the images are from my collection. There will

certainly be more books on him in the years to come, allowing us to fully appreciate his work.

**Q:** Why did you feel the time was right to publish it?

**A:** In the 1970s and 1980s, Pupul Jayakar, at the behest of the Indian government, promoted 'Other Masters of India', an idea that culminated in an exhibition organised by Jyotindra Jain at the Craft Museum in New Delhi in 1998. Numerous essays and books were published, and many exhibitions were organised during this period in India and abroad. In 1982, Bharat Bhawan, a museum fostering a dialogue between urban and rural contemporary art, was inaugurated in Bhopal. In the 1990s, with its booming economy, India promoted contemporary artists using a visual language closer to their Western counterparts, neglecting artists from tribal communities. It wasn't until the late 2010s that 'otherness' in India, as in Europe and the U.S., once again became a central focus of interest.

**Q:** How did you select the works featured in the book?

**A:** The selection was made not only based on his most beautiful paintings that I was able to discover but also on the quality of these works to be able to reproduce them accurately. There are still many wonderful paintings by Mashe in private and public collections in India that are not in my book and that may be the subject of future publications.

**Q:** Does the book recount his journey from his village to international museums?

**A:** The book focuses primarily on Mashe's artistic journey, his exhibitions, his encounters (notably the one I organised in Warli in 2003 with Richard Long, a pioneer of Land Art) and the numerous awards he has received.

## CALENDAR

### KGS drama festival

Get to witness new and popular plays to be staged by established Tamil theatre troupes in May as Krishna Gana Sabha presents the Summer Drama Fest between May 2 and 24, at KGS Arena, T. Nagar.

On the inaugural day, theatre veteran 'Appa' Ramesh will be conferred the 'Nataka Choodamani' title and Karthik Bhatt, the 'Iyakkunar Sigaram K. Balachander Award of Excellence in Theatre'. Actor Sachu, former Member Secretary of the Tamil Nadu Eyal Isai Nataka Mandram, will inaugurate and give away the awards, while Maadhu Balaji will felicitate the awardees. This will be followed by Crazy Creations' popular play *Meesai Aanalum Manaivi* at 7 p.m.

Plays to be staged on other days are: May 3, 7 p.m.: UAA's *Varadu Kutty*. May 7, 7 p.m.: Karpanai Kuthirai's *Chikku Bukku Kalyanam*. May 8, 7 p.m.: Fab Theatre's *Un Kannil Neer Vazhindhal*. May 9, 4.30 p.m.: Dummies Drama's *ThanimAI* and 7 p.m.: *Mr. Stranger*. May 10, 7 p.m.: S.Ve. Shekher's *Crazy Thieves in Palavakkam*. May 23, 7 p.m.: Three Entertains' *Mental Manadhil*. The curtains come down with Theatre Marina's *Never Odd Or Even* on May 24, 7 p.m. Tickets on Bookmyshow.

### Of stories and inheritance

Bhavdharna, an intimate gathering curated for women, comes to Chennai on April 25 from 4 p.m. to 6 p.m. at Pagir.

Designed as a space to explore inheritance in its many dimensions, the event is curated by Sarita Nair, storyteller and founder of Mumbai-based Heritage Stories & Performing Arts. Bhavdharna brings together guided imagery, art-based reflection, storytelling and a safe-sharing circle, inviting participants to bring heirloom pieces that hold memory and lineage.

The evening will feature performances by storyteller Jeeva Raghunath, spoken word artiste Lavanya Srinivas, contemporary dance artiste Preethi Bharadwaj and musician and Kalaripayattu artiste Subhashree Parthasarathy. To register contact 98202 18740 or send a mail to hspabysarita@gmail.com.

### An ode to Tyagaraja

Sri Thiagaraja Sangeetha Vidwath Samajam celebrates Tyagaraja Jayanthi with special concerts from April 24 to 28 at No. 10, Thiagarajapuram, Mylapore. Beginning with Ganapathy homam at 5 a.m., the programmes on the inaugural day will include the conferment of the title 'Sangeetha Seva Nirata' on vocalists Yogam Santhanam and Visalur Gurumurthi; mridangist K.R. Ganesh, ghatam artiste Suresh Vaidyanathan, and violinist Mullaivasal Chandramouli. This will be followed by Shertalai K.N. Ranganatha Sarma's vocal concert (7 p.m.). Legendary musician T.V. Gopalakrishnan will preside over. Concerts to be featured on other days are: April 25: Maharajapuram S. Ramachandran. April 26: Allam Durgaprasad (atchitraveena). April 27: Gayathri Girish. April 28: A.V.R. Roshani and A.V.R. Randhini (vocal).

# Konnakol gets a Zayn twist

The One Direction star, for the first time, makes shared culture central to his album's concept

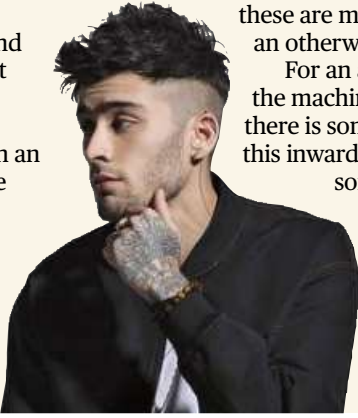
Rachel Rhine

The first time you register what Zayn Malik is doing on *Konnakol*, it almost slips past you. He strips rhythm back to its most human origin – breath, syllable, repetition – and rebuilds his sound from there. A beat seems to form, dissolve and then return in a different shape. It sounds familiar, but it really isn't. And that's when you realise this isn't percussion at all. What you are hearing is a voice set into rhythmic motion.

*Konnakol*, the art of performing percussion syllables vocally in Carnatic music, takes its premise seriously. Traditionally, Konnakol is the spoken language of rhythm, a way of reciting complex percussive patterns using syllables that correspond to instruments such as the mridangam. The word itself draws from Telugu and Tamil roots,

loosely translating to 'reciting rhythmic syllables', but the experience of it is far more intricate. It is counting, memory, breath control and improvisation, all at once. It is also crucially learned before the instrument is ever played.

There are moments in the album where you can hear this clearly. The production does not always arrive in the expected way. Instead, it accumulates, built from layered vocal runs, percussive ad-libs and looping phrases that mimic the recursive patterns of Carnatic rhythm. Even within an R&B framework, the songs feel counted rather than programmed. It gives the album a physicality that Zayn's previous work only



occasionally hinted at.

That is not to say *Konnakol* abandons the emotional terrain Zayn has long occupied. If 'Room Under the Stairs' was defined by introspection, this album is defined by recognition. There is a difference. Where the former lingered in feeling, this one interrogates it. On tracks such as 'Nusrat' and 'Used to the Blues', Zayn writes with a clarity that feels less performative and more accountable, acknowledging distance, emotional evasiveness and the slow work of unlearning both.

The cultural turn here is equally deliberate. Zayn has, since 'Mind of Mine', spoken about his South Asian identity in fragments. But *Konnakol* is the first time when he makes lineage central to an album's concept.

This evolution becomes sharper when placed against the long shadow of *One Direction*. In a year, where several of his former bandmates have returned with new material, Zayn's approach feels markedly different. There is little interest in revisiting the familiar contours of mainstream pop. If anything, *Konnakol* chooses discipline over immediacy, texture over recall.

For Indian listeners, the album carries an added layer of meaning. Zayn's connection to this audience has rarely been overstated, but it has always been present. During a Mumbai launch event, even as he remained hospitalised at the time of release, he addressed fans through a short video message: "India... I hope you guys have as much fun listening as I had making it. Love you." It is a simple sentiment, but one that resonates more deeply in the context of an album that references shared culture.

*Konnakol* is not without its uneven moments. Its mid-section occasionally loses momentum, and its commitment to mood can blur distinctions between tracks. Yet these are minor hesitations within an otherwise focused project.

For an artiste once defined by the machinery of global pop, there is something striking about this inward turn, toward

something as exacting and centuries-old as konnakol. It suggests a different kind of ambition, one that is less concerned with scale and more with structure.

**Cross-cultural notes**  
Zayn Malik performs during 'Stairway to the Sky' tour in January 2025 in Washington DC  
PHOTOS: GETTY IMAGES

